

Questions - Part 5: Negative Questions

A Quick-Reference Guide

When Answering Questions:

Positive and Negative Questions can have Positive or Negative Answers

Guide Notes	Sample Questions	Sample Answers
a) Clearly state what you want. b) In English, the answer to a negative question may use + or - to say the same things. c) Especially for negative questions, the positive or negative nature of the question is not connected to the positive or negative nature of answer. d) So answering a negative question with <u>only</u> a "Yes," or a "No," will not answer the question clearly.	(Both are ok.) Q: Didn't you like the chocolate? Q: Did you like the chocolate?	(All are ok.) A1: Yes , it wasn't very good. A2: No , it wasn't very good. A3: Yes , it was very good. A4: No , it was very good.

When asking questions:

The Negative "Can you? Do you?" Questions

The negative version of a question often has a very different meaning.

#	Focus	Negative Question	Meaning
1	Ability	Can't you _____?	Rude. Surprised disbelief. Seeking confirmation.
2.1	Any Time	Don't you _____?	Rude. Surprised disbelief. Seeking confirmation.
2.2	Frequency	*Don't you _____ often?	Rude. Surprised disbelief. Seeking confirmation.
3	Now	Aren't you _____ing (now)?	Rude. Surprised disbelief. Seeking confirmation.
4.1	Skill Level	Can't you _____ well?	Rude. Surprised disbelief. Seeking confirmation.
4.2	Skill Level	Aren't you good at _____ing?	Rude. Surprised disbelief. Seeking confirmation.
5	Cycle	When don't you _____?	Sarcastic rhetorical statement .
6.1	Past	When didn't you last (present form) ?	No meaning. Not used.
6.2	Past	When wasn't the last time you (past form) ?	No meaning. Not used.
7	One Time	Haven't you ever __ (past form) ?	Not rude. Surprised disbelief. Seeking confirmation.
8.1	Frequency	How often don't you _____?	No meaning. Not used.
8.2	Frequency	Don't you *ever _____?	Not rude. Surprised disbelief. Seeking confirmation.
8.3	Frequency	Don't you _____ *ever?	Not used.
9	Past	Didn't you _____ (optional: specific time) ?	Common . Seeking confirmation.
10	Future	Won't you _____ (optional: specific time) ?	Very Common . Please _____ with me. Invitation .
11.1	Future	When won't you next _____?	No meaning. Not used.
11.2	Future	When aren't you going to _____?	No meaning. Not used.
12	Like	Don't you like to _____?	Not rude. Surprised disbelief. Seeking confirmation.